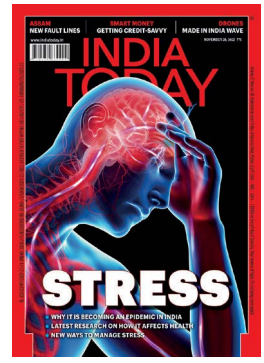
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The adage goes that hard work never kills anyone. Across cultures, it is seen as a virtue. The most often repeated mantra for well-being from doctors is to do everything in moderation. In today's pause-less offices of the 21st century, it is not possible. In fact, the Japanese, who are the most industrious nation in the world, have a name for its worst outcome—*Karoshi*. Or death by overwork. We are seeing more and more of this disturbing phenomenon of late. The issue came centre stage in India with a recent letter written by the distraught mother of Anna Sebastian Perayil, a bright, 26-year-old chartered accountant. Anna was just four months into her 'dream job' with a member firm of a global consultancy when she collapsed and died one day, allegedly due to overwork. The mother's letter, which ignited a nationwide debate on 'toxic work cultures', expressed the crux of it poignantly, citing how we "glorify overwork while neglecting the very human beings behind the roles...costing us the life of a young girl with so much potential". The words would resonate with many, but it seems more so with Gen Z, born between 1995 and 2012, the first half of whom have joined India's workforce. A 2023 survey of over 2,000 employees had 60.1 per cent reporting high or extreme stress, a 30.3 per cent increase over 2022. The highest figures, 64.4 per cent, were for the 21-30 age group. The 41-50 age group logged a comparatively lighter but still grim 53.6 per cent.



November 28, 2022

The world Gen Z has inherited in urban India is vastly different from that of their parents. Unlike them, they do not have to take care of basic necessities—food, home and financial security. For them, work is not about breadwinning but a more meaningful pursuit. Hence, there has been a rise in the gig economy, freelancing, and even pursuits like stand-up comedy. Not for them the long workday that less privileged employees, or those still in traditional sectors, have to clock. Fifty-one per cent of Indian employees work 49 hours per five-day work week, or 10 hours a day, according to the latest International Labour Organization data. This makes us the country with the world's second most prolonged work hours. India's IT companies may have imported the 'hustle' culture from Silicon Valley, but the malaise has now spread to the consulting, marketing, and accounting sectors. Globalisation and 24/7 connectivity have stretched that workday even more. As India became a service economy catering to clients worldwide, the workday of the Indian employee ceased to have a clear beginning or end. As a 30-year-old Delhi-based consulting professional says, "I would log in at 9 am sharp to work with my Hong Kong colleagues till 3 pm." After that, he would continue working on reports for the next day, often finishing around midnight. "Logging out at 12 or 1 am was normal," he says. That means 16 hours was regular.

The upshot is something familiar to all of us: while minute-by-minute digital updates have revolutionised our economies, they have also transformed the nature of work. Work is no longer something you leave behind at the office desk at 5 pm, you carry it home, on e-mail and WhatsApp, 24/7. The pandemic ushered in another anomalous acronym, WFH, or work from home. It survives in a hybrid avatar, making the workplace an even more amorphous space without respect for personal boundaries. It is no surprise that we have an epidemic of the early warning signs: extreme anxiety, despair, chronic fatigue and depression. The worst sufferers are either waking up dead and collapsing in the gym or ending their lives because they cannot handle the work pressure.

Global data released in 2021 showed that 745,194 people in 194 countries died of ischemic heart disease and stroke due to working long hours in 2016, a 29 per cent increase since 2000. Those who worked over 55 hours a week ran a verifiably higher risk than those in the 35-40 hours club. The latest Indian data shows that 62 per cent of workers report stress and burnout, triple the global average of 20 per cent. Gender comparisons gleaned from a 2023 study were equally worrying: women were more stressed than men due to poor work-life balance, exacerbated by societal expectations of house and care work, gender bias in office and lack of recognition. All this is in offices with a destabilising personnel turnover, with hypermobile youth increasingly reared on smartphones and less primed for social relations anchored in emotional security. Senior Associate Editor Sonal Khetarpal's cover story does more than etch out the gloomy Indian workscape as it mutated into a 24/7 global service sweatshop. We indicate ways in which companies must reassess their well-being strategies by acknowledging the devastating effects of stress on the human body. "Think of it like a rubber band," says psychologist Karuna Baskar. "If you stretch it too much, it will snap." We don't want new India to snap.

(Aroon Purie)